



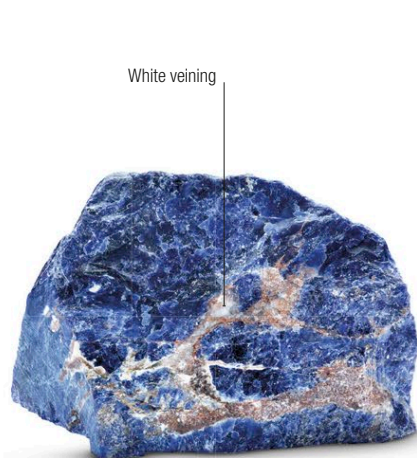
Sodalite

△ **Faceted oval cabochon** of semi-translucent sodalite

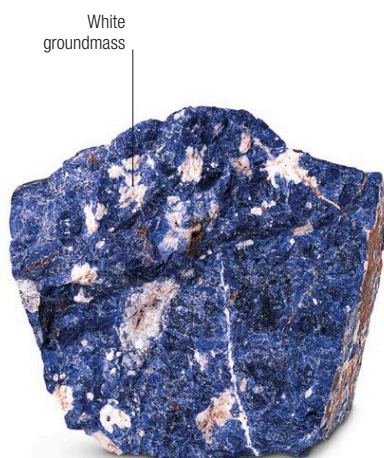
Sodalite is the mineral sometimes mistaken for lapis lazuli (see pp.174–77). It can also be one of the constituents of lapis lazuli, but is visually different, as the latter contains small crystals of pyrite. It is one of only a handful of minerals whose only use is as a gemstone – often veined with calcite, it is favoured by carvers for its interesting patterns. It is usually cut *en cabochon*, but rare transparent material from Mont-Saint-Hilaire, Canada, is faceted for collectors. Single pieces can weigh many kilograms.

Specification

Chemical name Sodium aluminosilicate chloride | **Formula** $\text{Na}_4\text{Al}_3\text{Si}_3\text{O}_{12}\text{Cl}$ | **Colours** Grey, white, blue | **Structure** Cubic
Hardness 5.5–6 | **SG** 2.1–2.4 | **RI** 1.48 | **Lustre** Vitreous to greasy | **Streak** White to light blue | **Locations** Canada, Russia, Germany, India, Canada, USA



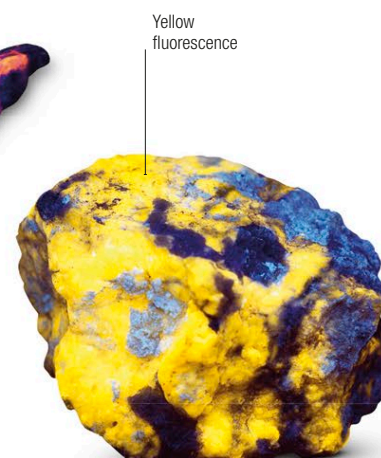
Uncut sodalite | Rough | This fine piece of sodalite rough demonstrates a good blue colouring with a minimum of the mineral's characteristic white veining.



Sodalite in rock | Rough | This specimen features a vivid blue sodalite scattered within the rock groundmass of another, white, feldspathoid.



Fluorescent sodalite | Colour variety | When illuminated under ultraviolet light, many sodalite pieces fluoresce (see pp.186–87), as can be seen in this specimen from India.



Yellow fluorescing sodalite | Colour variety | Under ultraviolet light, sodalites from different localities fluoresce in different colours (see pp.186–87). This example is Russian.

Sodalite
was named
in 1811
for its high
sodium
content



Cabochon | Cut | Sodalite is mostly cut *en cabochon*, with the cutter orienting the stone to get the best colour or pattern, as in this example.



Sodalite ornament | Carved | Sodalite is reasonably brittle, but in the hands of a skilled carver it can be shaped into pieces that are both attractive and amusing, such as this pig carved from unusually patterned material.

Mottled patterning